



Peeping and Spying: Public Gossip and Private Affairs of Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien in *The Plum in the Golden Vase*

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Abstract

In *The Plum in the Golden Vase*, Dame Wang offers one room in her teahouse and hence helps Hsi-men Ch'ing carry on an illicit affair with P'an Ch'in-lien. The personal affair does not remain as a secret, but is leaked to the neighborhood in less than half a month. "A certain busybody" on the street incites Yün-ko to look for Hsi-men Ch'ing in Dame Wang's teahouse. The scene intrigues me in that two separate environments—a public street and a private room for adultery in the teahouse—intersect because of Yün-ko's unauthorized entrance to the teahouse. How does the social dynamic, in terms of both characters and environment, affect the private affair of Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien? In this paper, I will argue that the minor character Yün-ko becomes a narrative instrument for “多口人” to bring public gossip into the teahouse and to connect public rumors with private affair. “多口人” and Amethyst Street establish a social dynamic that serves as a backstage to produce troubles and complicate conflicts for the private affair between Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien. Before answering the question, I will first answer a series of subsequent questions by analyzing Chapter 4, 5 and 9: What is the function of “a certain busybody” on the street? What is the function of a minor character Yün-ko in the novel? What is the function of the social environment like a street?

Gestures such as eavesdropping, peeping and spying keep repeating throughout *The Plum in the Golden Vase*. The story becomes even more clichéd whenever a maid quietly stands by the door to hear people's talking inside the room or one of the wives peeps through the window to observe what happens inside. Although none of the characters are real human beings, they still invite readers to focus on their words and actions and to approach their interiority. Rather than focus on the main characters' peeping and spying inside Hsi-men Ch'ing's garden, this paper will extend the notion of peeping and spying from the household to the street outside as well as from main characters to marginal characters. The demarcation between what is public and what is private. In spite of the trite plot, actions of peeping and spying actually signify a demarcation between public space and private space. Privacy is not confined to household, but depends on the more public environment it compared to. Even outside the household, a room in the teahouse becomes a relatively private space when compared to Amethyst Street—a larger public street. People-on-the-street's curiosity about peeping into Hsi-men and Ch'in-lien's relationship further enhances the privacy of the affair as the two become the object of the voyeuristic gazing.

In Chapter 4, as Yün-ko looks for Hsi-men Ch'ing on the street to sell pears to him, “a certain “多口人”” suggests that Yün-ko should go to Dame Wang's teahouse:

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As he was going his rounds a certain "多口人" said to him, "Yün-ko, if that's who you're looking for, I can tell you a place where you'll be sure to find him."

"Listen to me," said the "多口人". "Hsi-men Ch'ing is carrying on an affair with the wife of Wu the Elder, who sells steamed wheat cakes. Every day he can be found sitting around in Dame Wang's teashop on Amethyst Street. He's almost certainly there at this very moment. You're still just a kid, so even if you walk right in on him it won't make any difference." [1].

Noticeably, people wandering along the street are referred to as "'多口人' 多口人," a generalized term that erases the individuality of passers-by and extracts collective attributes of minor characters on the street. The term "多口人" metaphorically associates people's gossipy feature with the possession of multiple mouths to speak at the same time; similar to the phrase 多嘴, the term also implies people's meddlesomeness that they talk about trifle matters unrelated to themselves. When encountering the phrase "一等多口人" in the Chinese text, we tend to consider a group of people on the street categorized as 多口人. However, a comparison of Chapter 4 and Chapter 9 (later discussed in this paper) shows that it is actually only one single individual is referred to as 多口人, who incites Yün-ko to go to the teahouse and gives Wu Sung hints. David Roy's translation as "a certain busybody" also validates that busybody is one same individual instead of a kind of people.

In the context, when Yün-ko looks for Hsi-men Ch'ing to sell pears, the "多口人" not only incites him to go to Dame Wang's teahouse, but also intentionally reveals the illicit affair between Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien in front of Yün-ko. The words of "多口人" embody a social tendency to spy into others' privacy and a process of converting Yün-ko to another certain "多口人". The meddlesomeness of people on the street connects the social environment with Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien. It is the "多口人" that incites Yün-ko to force an entrance into Dame Wang's teahouse to find Hsi-men Ch'ing and understates the consequence by pointing out that Yün-ko is "just a kid." Yün-ko's unauthorized entrance blatantly provokes Dame Wang that an illicit affair arranged by her is leaked out to the public and that everyone knows that Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien meet at the teahouse. Dame Wang's consecutive questions such as "What brings you here, Yün-ko?,"² "What gentleman is that?"³ and "And what two characters might they be?"⁴ manifest her surprise and unawareness that a child knows her secretive business. Therefore, Yün-ko becomes an instrument to carry on 多口人's subjective incitement and puts trifling talks into action. 多口人 indirectly ridicules Dame Wang through a child and complicates the affair with social intervention. Due to Yün-ko's young age, people will attribute the unauthorized entrance to child's recklessness rather than someone's deliberate scheme. Thus, 多口人 deliberately offers Yün-ko

information about Hsi-men Ch'ing, indirectly jeers at Dame Wang and complicates the private affair between Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien with social involvement. Yün-ko functions as an instrument to carry out 多口人's subjective incitements and to put rumors on the street into action, successfully connecting public gossip with private affairs.

Besides the function of Yün-ko and 多口人 in the scene in Chapter 4, by comparing two scenes from Chapter 5 and Chapter 9 respectively, I will analyze the function of a street as a social environment in the novel. At the beginning of the Chapter 5, the story continues as Yün-ko is driven out of the teahouse by Dame Wang:

"He hadn't gone more than two blocks when whom should he see but Wu the Elder, shouldering his load of steamed wheat cakes, coming along the very street he was on."⁵

The description suggests that Wu the Elder passes Amethyst Street every day to sell steamed wheat cakes, the same street where Yün-ko just passes through, but why is Wu the Elder kept in the dark? Moreover, a certain 多口人 occurs for another time in Chapter 9 after Wu Sung walks along the street to ask about his brother's death and his sister-in-law's remarriage:

The neighbors who lived on that street knew perfectly well what had happened, but they were all afraid of Hsi-men Ch'ing, so no one cared to interfere.

All they would say was, "Captain, there's no need to enquire any further. Dame Wang lives right next door. Just ask Dame Wang and you'll find out what you want to know." A certain "多口人" also told him, "That Yün-ko who sells pears and Ho the Ninth, the coroner's assistant, are two people who know a good deal about it."⁶

There are two kinds of people on the street—neighbors and 多口人. Neighbors know gossip as well, but they do not dare to interfere with the private affair because they are afraid of Hsi-men Ch'ing. 多口人 has a privileged knowledge of gossip and a meddlesome tendency to intervene in private affairs. He selects people to share with information or deliberately reveal information in order to make trouble. Although Yün-ko and Wu the Elder both pass through Amethyst street, Wu the Elder remains unaware of his wife's illicit affair, but Yün-ko is informed of the secret by the 多口人. 多口人's selective gesture to reveal secrets to Yün-ko rather than Wu the Elder betrays his malicious intention to dramatize the problem inside Wu the Elder's household. By inciting Yün-ko to conduct his own scheme, 多口人 fabricates a spectatorship for himself so that he could watch a farcical conflict between Dame Wang and Yün-ko in the distance.

Moreover, in the case of Wu Sung, 多口人 adds that Yün-ko and Ho the Ninth can help Wu Sung figure out his brother's death. 多口人 steps out to disclose information

when neighbors hesitate to do so. It is noticeable that he mentions Yün-ko, who gets involved in the affair due to "多口人" per se. He guides Wu Sung to discover the truth by leaking out secrets fabricated by himself, redoubling the conflict he creates in former chapters. More and more people—Yün-ko, Ho the Ninth and now Wu Sung—become involved into the private affair between Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien. Thus, 多口人 and Amethyst street constitute a social dynamic which keeps including and excluding both people and information. The social dynamic serves as a backstage to produce possibilities of troubles for the private affair and complicate conflicts by adding social interventions. Social dynamic and personal affairs intersect because of rumors, social others and the street per se.

Besides textual analyses of several scenes concerning Yün-ko and the illicit affair between Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien in Chapter 4, 5 and 9, we can also approach the relationship between social dynamic and personal affairs through the lens of illustrations in the novel. Although illustration visually represent selected scenes from *The Plum in the Golden Vase*, I will approach those illustrations by only focusing on the architecture instead of visual representation of the plot. Depiction of Dame Wang's teahouse and the room where Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien meets will help us to visually understand the spatial relationship between outside social dynamic and inside private affair.

In Chapter 2, there is an illustration captioned "Beneath the Blind Hsi-men Ch'ing Meets Chin-lien."⁷ We can see from the illustration that Ch'in-lien's house is right next to Dame Wang's teahouse and that there are huge hollow windows on the walls. Therefore, everyone on the street can see whoever comes to the teahouse and hear the conversations inside the teahouse. If people on the street frequently see Hsi-men Ch'ing and Ch'in-lien entering the teahouse, they tend guess there is a secretive relation between the two. The open architectural structure of the teahouse enables social spying into what happens inside. Moreover, in Chapter 5, there is an illustration captioned "Yün-ko Lends a Hand by Cursing Dame Wang."⁸ This illustration allows us to see the backside the teahouse and the private room where Hsi-men Ch'ing meets P'an Ch'in-lien. As Dame Wang states that "in every house there are areas that private and areas that are public,"⁹ it is true that different parts of the teahouse serve for different purposes. The room for adultery stays far away from the outside street and is distinguished from the area for guests. It creates a private space within a public environment, evading

direct social observation. Hence, the disclosure of the secrets from the private room to the outside street might indicate gossip based on assumptions rather than peeping.

Eventually, I will go back to my question proposed at the beginning of this paper—"how does the social dynamic, in terms of both characters and environment, affect the private affair of Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien?" A close reading of selected scenes concerning Yün-ko in Chapter 4, 5 and 9 embodies the function of Yün-ko and 多口人 in the novel. Yün-ko becomes an instrument to put 多口人's incitements into practice and brings rumors on the street into Dame Wang's teahouse, connecting public gossip and private affairs. Furthermore, 多口人 and Amethyst Street establish a social dynamic which serves as a backstage to produce troubles and complicate conflicts for the private affair between Hsi-men Ch'ing and P'an Ch'in-lien. Social dynamic and personal affair intersect because of gossip, social others and the street environment.

Beside textual analyses, illustrations in the novel also offer us a more direct visual representation of architectures such as the teahouse and room for adultery.

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